

Dysfunctional Teams Paper

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LE7549: Dynamics of Team Leadership

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Introduction

This paper examines the five dysfunctions that can negatively affect teams, and how to overcome them. The source text is Patrick Lencioni's *The Five Dysfunctions of a Team: A Leadership Fable*. In his book, he has a story of how a hero fixes a dysfunctional team. I will include my own personal triumph over dysfunctions, and how I plan to overcome others.

Lencioni's book on Leadership is an interesting one. It focuses on dysfunctions, what goes wrong with teams, rather than what we should do to make things right. Of course, Lencioni provides ways to fix these dysfunctions, but it's interesting that he focuses on the problem first rather than the beautiful ideal of what we aim towards.

I believe this is a very good approach because if we want to make something better, we need to look at what is wrong and fix it so that we can improve. By looking at only the positives, we don't grow.

Also, what I loved about Lencioni's book is that it includes a long story about a heroine who saves a company's team. It includes all the nitty gritty detail and all the difficulties and friction that comes along with trying to organize and lead a team. I thought it was very realistic, and very fun to read.

At the end of the book, Lencioni writes in an academic and theoretical fashion and lists five dysfunctions that were presented in the story, and analyzes them, and proposes solutions to each dysfunction.

I thought that it was ingenious to choose the dysfunctions that he chose. I would never have thought that leadership includes things like trust and vulnerability. I would have thought that leadership includes things like forcing people to follow your opinion. But Lencioni, although he may not be Christian, has a very servant-leadership approach, which is the approach that Jesus followed. Which leads to a very interesting question of whether non-Christian approaches to leadership are congruent with Christian leadership.

Can a pastor follow a business book in order to organize and lead his church? John MacArthur in his book *The Gospel According to Jesus* says, "No way."

But in contrast to MacArthur, I think we have valuable things to learn about the secret of success from non-Christian business leaders because non-Christians are still human beings, just as Christians are. And God made all things, not just the church. And the church is an organization, just as a business is one.

And so, I conclude that it is too conservative to only stick to Christian material in a big and complex world. We need business advice, science, and all sorts of knowledge in order to navigate this complex world we are in.

In order to lead people in this complex world, we have to understand the complexity of this world. And in the book, we see that there are a variety of characters that we may face in society.

For example, the seven people listed in the beginning of the book, may be seven people who are church members that we need to lead. We must understand that church members may not even be Christian.

To look at the profile of these seven people, let's look at the book. Jeff "raised a considerable amount of the company's initial money and attracted many of the current executives." As we can see, Jeff has skills in raising capital funds, a skill that is not explicitly stated in the Bible. But even the Bible speaks of the business of building the Temple that Solomon built. And Solomon and Hiram used business to build the temple.

Mikey was "brand-building genius. Which made it all the more astonishing that she lacked a few key social graces" (p. 20). And we must understand that brand-building for businesses is a skill that can be used for logos and YouTube for churches. And a pastor must be

able to shepherd a lady like Mikey who may lack some social skills. This is all things not explicitly stated in the Bible, but are included in real life churches and the world.

“Martin Gilmore was the closest thing that DecisionTech had to an inventor. He had designed the original specs for the company's flagship product, and although others had done much of the actual product development, the executives often said that Martin was the keeper of the crown jewels” (p. 21).

As we can see here, Martin is a genius when it comes to specs and details about the technical aspects of a product. He loves technology. This is a real person, who has interest in secular subject matters, and definitely, if he is a member of our church, we must lead him towards Christ and toward sanctification.

JR on the other hand, was flaky. He never kept his appointments. He “acknowledged having made a commitment that went unfulfilled, he apologized profusely to whomever he had let down” (p. 22). And in church, we may meet many people who are uncommitted to our ministry and don't love our mission as much as we do. And we have to lead them.

And what I found fascinating was that the heroine of the book would bring all sorts of different types of people together, who each had their unique strengths and weaknesses, and got them to work together to succeed. I think that it is a very difficult thing to lead a company or a church because everyone is going to have friction with each other. Everyone has different opinions, and people may get upset that someone else conflicts with them.

“Carlos spoke very little, but whenever he did, he had something important and constructive to say” (p. 23). I found this interesting about Carlos because I myself don't speak much unless I really have to. I am so similar to Carlos. But when we speak, we say something that is positive and makes things improve drastically.

I'm sure there are people who are the opposite - who speak too much and have little effect. And thus, we see there is a range of personalities and strengths and weaknesses, and the Bible is not enough, we need real world skills to lead a team and a church.

Dysfunction 1: Absence of Trust

This dysfunction is my favorite because I think it is the most important. The book says trust is “confidence among team members that their peers' intentions are good” (p. 195). I think that this can only be possible if truly the peers are good people. And when I build a team, the first thing I want is people who are good and that I can truly trust.

Trust cannot ever be faked. If I have some evil person on my team, I will never trust him. But if I assemble a team of good people who come from my network that I trust, then I can trust them.

And so, the focus is assembling the team. And when we hire people, we want to hire people who come from our network that we already trust. We don't want to hire strangers.

And I think it's very fun and important to play games that build trust - even physical activities. Trust is built one brick at a time, and it takes time.

Dysfunction 2: Fear of Conflict

This dysfunction is very wisely chosen by the author because conflict is the focus of what goes wrong with teams. And focusing on the problem is the best way to fix the problem.

Conflict is essentially the main problem when we assemble a group of people who have different ideas and personalities. They rub each other the wrong way, and we get upset.

But this is a good thing, according to the author. We need to debate with each other and have strong differing opinions in order to succeed and improve.

“May the best man win.”

“It’s fair game.”

Those are some of the phrases that should be pronounced more - a fair fight where the best opinion and person wins, and everyone acknowledges the winner.

As the author says, “unfortunately, conflict is considered taboo in many situations, especially at work” (202).

Dysfunction 3: Lack of Commitment

I think this is hardest dysfunction to overcome. The only way to overcome it is to truly have a good product or a good mission in our church or organization.

If the purpose and core is not worthy, it is impossible to truly attract people. It may actually be possible, such as McDonald’s, but if the goal and purpose is not good, it has no effect in the kingdom of God.

When we build a church we must have a particular goal in mind that is related to the Great Commission. If I were to build a church, I would make my church’s mission to “save all.” I think it’s so important to make the church’s purpose to save our neighbor and to make evangelism a priority.

If we see our neighbor in pain and suffering, and we are able to alleviate that pain, is that not a great purpose? I think so many people would be sympathetic toward that mission because we are all in pain and have been in severe pain at one point in our life. And having the mission to alleviate pain and share the gospel is a mission that would solve this dysfunction.

Every business and organization and church should have the mission to make the world better and alleviate pain and share Christ.

Dysfunction 4: Avoidance of Accountability

The author defines accountability as “the willingness of team members to call their peers on performance or behaviors that might hurt the team” (212). And I think this is a very important dysfunction to focus on because we need to end foul play.

If someone is harming another person, we must stop this - and this is in any context - in business, church, or society. It’s one thing to sin and make your own life a little bit worse, but it’s another thing to harm the team or other people.

This is where the authority of the team leader is important and we need to have a system in place in order to enforce punishment or justice or fair play.

Much can be said here, but I think this is the darkest and more difficult dysfunction to talk about.

Dysfunction 5: Inattention to Results

“The ultimate dysfunction of a team is the tendency of members to care about something other than the collective goals of the group” (216). And I must disagree to a degree.

I believe that if everyone is self-interested to a degree, we can progress a little bit better.

No one is going to bet their salvation on a particular church organization, and no one is going to bet all their life on a business. We are all self-interested to a degree.

And this self-interest allows us to have a share or stake in the business or church and lead the church in the direction we want.

The solution to this dysfunction is not to make everyone blindly follow the group in some group or herd psychology; but to make everyone’s individual voices heard. The church needs to

listen to the flock and respond to the needs of the flock, not just have the flock and team follow everything that the group leader instantiates.

My Dysfunction

My dysfunction is the problem of having to follow a group or team blindly. I hate losing my individuality. I don't want to put the group's needs and goals above my own. I am self-interested.

And I think this is a good thing. This is the basis for our democracy. We don't want the leader and President to do whatever he wants - we want to elect and control the President to a degree through the people's power and vote.

And so the solution to making a country or church or team important and valuable to the eyes of the members is not to make them blindly follow, but to show them that they have a personal self-interest and stake in the organization.

If this organization goes well, it will benefit *you*. And *you* can determine the direction of the organization - you have power!

I plan to overcome this dysfunction by being more self-interested and valuing myself more, instead of just following my country or society or church blindly.

In conclusion, there are many things to discuss about teams, churches, and organizations. Because we live in the 21st century, we cannot be simple minded and just know the Bible alone - we must be able to manage a modern team. And to do this, we need to know how to fix dysfunctions that happen due to psychology, politics, and business theory. We need to have a truly good purpose to make a team work, and a church must focus on the Great Commission to make its team successful.

Declaration

I have read all the course material.

Bibliography

Bibliography

Lencioni, Patrick. *The Five Dysfunctions of a Team: A Leadership Fable*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 2002.